James Van Nguyen

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PROFILE

Kubernetes Escalation Engineer with 7+ years of experience in DevSecOps, Rancher / RKE2, and AWS, resolving high severity production issues for 50+ enterprise customers in healthcare, financial, and energy.

CORE COMPETENCIES

Industries: Healthcare | Financial | Energy | Automotive
Artifact and Registry Management: Harbor | JFrog Artifactory
Cloud Providers: Amazon Web Services (AWS) | Google Cloud Platform (GCP)
Operating Systems: Linux (SLES / RHEL / Ubuntu)
Observability: Prometheus | Grafana | Elasticsearch | Kibana
Infrastructure Provisioning: HashiCorp Terraform | HashiCorp Sentinel | AWS CloudFormation | Crossplane
Container Orchestration & Tools: Kubernetes | Rancher | RKE2 | K3s | EKS | Helm | Kustomize
Configuration Management: Ansible | Chef
Secret Management: HashiCorp Vault | AWS Parameter Store | AWS Secrets Manager
Security: NeuVector | Kubewarden | AWS GuardDuty | AWS WAF | SonarQube | Trivy
Scripting: Bash | Python
CI/CD: AWS CodePipeline | ArgoCD | GitOps | Azure DevOps | Jenkins
Security, Compliance and Business Continuity: DevSecOps | HIPAA | PCI DSS
Methodologies: Scrum / Agile | Kanban

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Employer: SUSE, Los Angeles, CA (Sept '26-Present)
Role: Kubernetes Escalation Engineer
Responsibilities:

- Serve as the technical escalation point for complex, high severity Kubernetes and Rancher issues, performing root cause analysis across networking, etcd, control plane, and workload failures to restore service for enterprise customers while consistently meeting SLA commitments
- Partner with engineering and product teams to reproduce and document product defects, contribute to knowledge base articles and internal runbooks, and mentor support engineers on advanced troubleshooting techniques
- Analyze Linux system logs, Kubernetes metrics, and etcd and kube-apiserver behavior to diagnose performance degradation, node instability, and cluster networking failures (CNI, DNS, ingress) in production Rancher / RKE2 environments

Employer: SUSE, Los Angeles, CA (May '24-Sept '26)
Role: Kubernetes Support Engineer
Responsibilities:

- Supported 50+ enterprise customers across RKE, RKE2, K3s, and EKS, advising on highly available Kubernetes environments with security hardening, RBAC policies, and network segmentation to meet compliance requirements
- Advised clients in implementing comprehensive observability stacks using Prometheus, Grafana, and centralized logging
- Collaborated with customers to establish GitOps practices, infrastructure-as-code standards, and secrets management solutions for secure, repeatable deployments
- Assisted in the deployment of NeuVector through Rancher for customers to automate container vulnerability scanning, runtime protection, and compliance reporting across managed clusters
- Guided customers through CIS benchmark hardening for RKE2 clusters to meet security and compliance requirements

Employer: Eviden, Chicago, IL (Sept '21-June '24)
Role: Senior DevOps Engineer
Responsibilities:

- Assisted in the migration from Terraform Enterprise to Crossplane for a medical institution, implementing controllers and compositions to automate provisioning and lifecycle management of GCP resources and reduce manual deployments
- Integrated ArgoCD with Azure DevOps to enforce a GitOps workflow for quicker continuous delivery, rollbacks, and version control changes

- Architected a Terraform / Rancher deployment that saved a financial institution over $500K in AWS costs
- Designed and automated a Jenkins CI/CD pipeline to deploy Rancher UI, integrating SonarQube for automated code quality and security scanning that caught vulnerabilities before deployment and reduced deployment time by half
- Expanded HashiCorp Vault for enterprise secret management, deploying the Vault Sidecar Injector via Helm to integrate Kubernetes clusters with Vault, reducing security vulnerabilities and improving compliance adherence
- Built and maintained reusable Terraform modules and a private module registry for centralized version control, used to provision AWS resources (EC2, load balancers, IAM, Route 53) across application teams
- Deployed AWS GuardDuty and AWS WAF using Terraform for threat detection and web application firewall rules to enforce security standards across environments
- Developed Ansible Playbooks for streamlined installation and deployment of Kubernetes Clusters on Rancher, effectively minimizing manual deployment tasks for teams
- Mentored junior engineers and authored 20+ technical guides that onboarded 15+ teams onto Terraform Enterprise, Kubernetes, and HashiCorp Vault

Employer: Nexient, Ann Arbor, MI (Jan '19-Sept '21)
Role: DevOps Engineer II
Responsibilities:

- Contributed to a multi cloud Azure / AWS project for a gas and energy company, building a deployment system designed for fault tolerance, high availability, and disaster recovery
- Automated frontend application deployment using Bash, Python, GitHub, AWS CodeBuild, and CodePipeline, giving developers a repeatable, self service release process
- Wrote cloud agnostic Bash scripts that ran against both the AWS and Azure CLIs, and used Azure DevOps Pipelines to deploy infrastructure and Azure Function Apps as a backend for frontend
- Built CloudFormation and Lambda workflows to automate CloudFront and S3 website management, and helped implement a Lambda@Edge solution for conditional redirection
- Implemented Elasticsearch and Kibana in Java applications to monitor servers and support real-time troubleshooting

EDUCATION

Bachelor of Science in Biomolecular Science and English Language and Literature – University of Michigan
Certifications: Kubernetes and Cloud Native Security Associate (KCSA), Kubernetes and Cloud Native Associate (KCNA), Certified Kubernetes Administrator (CKA), HashiCorp Certified: Terraform Associate, AWS Certified Cloud Practitioner